Whole-person education at Canoe Valley supports the development of underlying capacities in each student that lead to positive educational outcomes and long-term flourishing.

When we focus on capacities like self-motivation, self-expression, interpersonal intelligence, connection to place, and sense of purpose, in addition to core skills and knowledge, we widen the academic experience into something much bigger, and give students an invaluable foundation that supports them in every area of life.

This includes educational success. Take the example of self-motivation: a wealth of research has shown that the best predictor of high achievement is not how much we know, or even what we are able to do, but how engaged we are in the learning process—how readily we are able to follow our curiosity, discover our passions, and persevere in our heart's work.

MORE INFO

To learn more about how all this fits together in our learning program, as well as about our campus's wild setting and the unique institutional features of our school, please read our program guide (linked in the QR code below).

HOW TO ENROLL

We are welcoming enrollment interest from families of students aged 12-18 for our anticipated fall 2027 opening. We are planning on a first-year enrollment size of about 15 students, and aim to grow within a few years to about 30-40 students in two mixed-age programs, a lower and an upper level. Our enrollment application will be available in late 2026; we anticipate significant interest, so please consider joining our pre-enrollment waitlist (linked in the QR code below).

Canoe Valley School

A whole-person secondary school for Decorah, Iowa

SCHOOL SNAPSHOT

Greetings from Canoe Valley School!

We are a newly forming secondary school in rural Winneshiek County, located on a beautiful 40 acre campus in a tributary valley of Canoe Creek. Our educational approach centers on whole-person, place-based learning, and we offer a one-of-a-kind program that supports individual development, helps students build strong relationships with others and with the natural world, and provides carefully designed preparation for college and other post-secondary pathways.

WE OFFER

A customizable curriculum that supports whole-person development, fostering self-motivation, self-discovery, healthy relationships, and connection to place, alongside foundational knowledge in core subject areas.

A real-world, project-based learning approach driven by student curiosity, inspiring and talented teachers, and the school's outdoor campus.

Elective classes drawn from a list shaped by students and teachers.

Thoughtfully designed supplemental programs in reading and math.

Arts and self-expression across the curriculum.

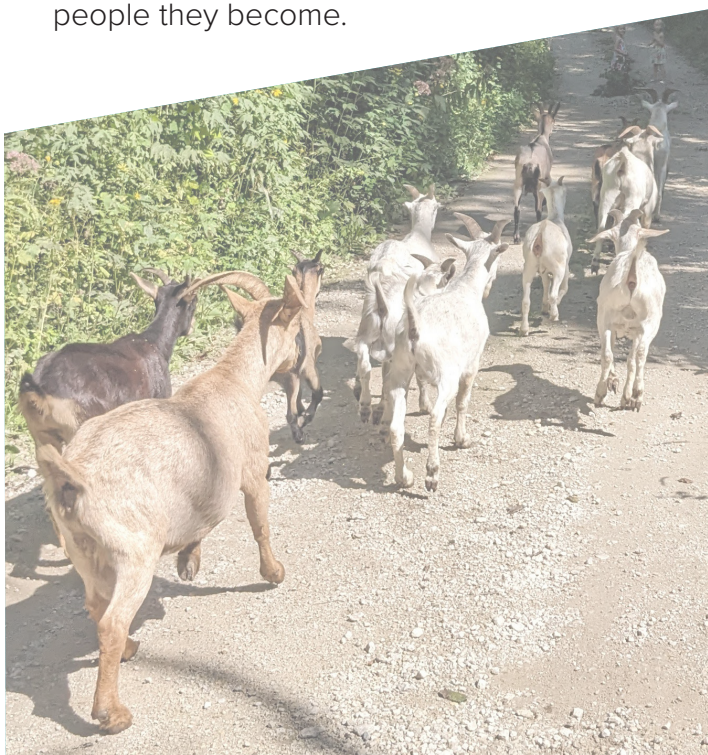
Farm-based learning opportunities on the small regenerative farm stewarded by our partner organization, ReRooted Connections.

Multi-age groupings and opportunities for peer learning, including ample time for unstructured play and exploration.

Service-learning activities for responsibility and purpose throughout the curriculum, including opportunities for meaningful outdoor and farm-based work.

Regular field trips and an annual off-site expedition.

And much more!

CAMPUS LIFE

Connection to place is central to our approach, and we treat the land around us as a living laboratory. Farm and wilderness experiences are integral to how students learn at Canoe Valley—giving them daily opportunities to observe, inquire, build, grow, and care for the world around them. Our outdoor campus isn't an add-on; it's a dynamic extension of the classroom where young people develop practical skills, ecological literacy, and a deep sense of belonging. Whether tending gardens, exploring forests, restoring habitat, or working alongside community partners, students come to understand themselves as capable contributors within a larger living system. This immersive relationship with the land cultivates confidence, curiosity, and stewardship—qualities that shape not only their education, but the kind of people they become.